

Ibn al-Qifti, Tarikh al-Hukama

English Translation

Modern LaTeX Editions of Public-Domain Mathematics Manuscripts

IBN AL-QIFTĪ'S
TĀRĪKH AL-ḤUKAMĀ'
History of the Learned

كِتَابُ تَارِيخِ الْحُكَمَاءِ

لِجَمَالِ الدِّينِ أَبِي الْحَسَنِ عَلِيِّ بْنِ يُوسُفَ الْقُفُطِيِّ

BILINGUAL EDITION — ZWEISPRACHIGE AUSGABE — □□□□□□ □□□□□□□□

LEFT: Arabic Text || RIGHT: English Translation

ARABISCH: LINKS || ENGLISCH: RECHTS

Based on the edition by

Prof. Dr. Julius Lippert

Leipzig, Dieterich'sche Verlagsbuchhandlung, 1903

AUF GRUND DER VORARBEITEN AUG. MÜLLER'S

With critical apparatus and parallel English translations

بِتَأْيِيدِ اللَّهِ الْمُؤَفَّقِ

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Preface — Vorwort — □□□□□

This bilingual edition presents the Arabic text of Ibn al-Qiftī's تاريخ الحكماء (Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā', "History of the Learned") alongside English translations. The Arabic text is based on the critical edition prepared by Prof. Dr. Julius Lippert (Leipzig, 1903), which was itself founded upon the preparatory work of August Müller. The present edition aims to make this foundational biographical dictionary accessible to historians of mathematics and science who do not read Arabic.

Zur dieser Ausgabe:

Zweck dieser Zeilen ist es, diejenigen unter den Weisen zu erwähnen, deren Ruhm berühmt geworden ist, aus jedem Stamm und jeder Nation, alt und neu, bis zu meiner Zeit.

قَصَدْنَا بِهَذِهِ الطَّبْعَةِ أَنْ نُنَيِّحَ هَذَا الْكِتَابَ الْمُهِّمَّ لِطُلَّابِ تَارِيخِ الْعُلُومِ

1 Introduction to the Work

Jamāl al-Dīn Abū al-Ḥasan ‘Alī ibn Yūsuf ibn Ibrāhīm ibn ‘Abd al-Wāḥid al-Shaybānī al-Qiftī (1172–1248 CE) was an Egyptian Arab scholar, historian, and Ayyubid vizier. Born in Qift (Coptos) in Upper Egypt, he studied in Cairo before moving to Jerusalem and later Aleppo, where he compiled most of his works. Of the twenty-six works known by title, only two survive: *Inbāh al-Ruwāt ‘alā Anbāh al-Nuḥāt* (containing some thousand biographies of Muslim scholars) and the present work.

The *تاريخ الحكماء* (*Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā’*, “History of the Learned”) is a biographical dictionary of 414 physicians, philosophers, astronomers, and scientists — including Greeks, Indians, Persians, and Arabs. The text preserved today is an epitome made in 1249/647 AH by *محمد بن علي الخطيب* (Muḥammad ibn ‘Alī al-Khaṭībī al-Zawzanī), a year after Ibn al-Qiftī’s death, from the longer original titled *كتاب إخبار العلماء بأخبار الحكماء* (*Kitāb Ikḥār al-‘Ulamā’ bi-Akḥbār al-Ḥukamā’*).

The present edition was prepared by **Prof. Dr. Julius Lippert** (1839–1909), building upon the preparatory work of August Müller. It was published in Leipzig by Dieterich’sche Verlagsbuchhandlung in 1903, with the support of the Royal Academy of Sciences in Berlin.

On the Arabic Text

The Arabic text in this edition follows the standard conventions of 19th-century Orientalist printing. The *hamza* and diacritical points are supplied where the manuscripts are ambiguous or defective. The editorial footnotes indicate manuscript variants using the sigla listed below.

Editorial Sigla

Siglum	Description
A	Berlin, Königliche Bibliothek, Cod. or. quart. 786
B	Berlin, Königliche Bibliothek, Cod. or. oct. 10053
C	Kairo, Biblothèque Nationale, Ms. I
D	Kairo, Biblothèque Nationale, Ms. II
V	Wien, Kaiserliche Hofbibliothek, Cod. Mixt. 783
M	München, Königliche Hof- und Staatsbibliothek, Cod. ar. 651

Note: The word قَفَّيْتُهُ (qaffaytuhu) here means “I arranged it alphabetically” (literally: “I followed the letters [of the alphabet]”). This alphabetical arrangement was one of the earliest examples of systematic biographical dictionary arrangement in Arabic literature.

3 The Ancient Greeks

3.1 Thales [ثَالِس] [ثَالِس]

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Thales — he is from the people of Miletus — and he lived in the time of King Cyrus, and he was the first to discourse on causes and reasons. He travelled to Egypt and studied with the astrologers, then returned to his country. He was the first to establish that the Moon receives its light from the Sun, and that the Sun is eclipsed according to calculation.

3.2 Pythagoras فَيْثَاغُورَسْ

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 .۞۞۞۞۞۞۞ *Pythagoras the Samian — he is*
from the people of Tyre — was the first to
discourse on divine science (al-ʿilm al-ilāhī),
and Socrates followed him in that.
Pythagoras had left Egypt after studying
with the astrologers and the Hermetists, and
remained at that for forty years; then he
returned to Tyre and departed from there to
Italy, where he settled. He used to forbid the
eating of beans and meat.

The tradition of Pythagoras studying in Egypt with the “astrologers and Hermetists” connects Greek wisdom to the Egyptian Hermetic tradition. The forty-year sojourn reflects the standard Arabic account of Pythagoras’s intellectual biography.

3.3 Socrates سُقْرَاطُ

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Socrates, disciple of Pythagoras, was called among the non-Arabs “Socrates.” He did not compose books, but rather spoke in the streets and marketplaces. He called to the abandonment of desires and the cultivation of noble virtues.

3.4 Plato أفلاطون

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 □□□□□□□□□□□□ □□□ .□□□□□□□□□□ *Plato the*
Platonist — he was the least disposed to
 dwell in houses — and he had a strong love
 for Socrates, and he inherited noble
 character traits from Socrates. He composed
 works on optics and established that looking
 at the naked Sun corrupts the eyesight, while
 looking at it in water or through glass does
 not corrupt it.

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 .□□□□□□□□□□□ Aristotle, disciple of Plato,
 was the most prolific composer of books
 among them, and the most comprehensive in
 the sciences. He composed on every art of
 the arts. Plato used to call him “the chick of
 the Academy” because of the strength of his
 intelligence.

4.1 Euclid اُقْلِيدُسْ

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 .۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ *Euclid: a scholar in geometry*
(hay'a), and he composed on it a famous
book called "The Elements" (al-Uṣūl). Before
that he had composed a book on the risings
of the stars which he called Phaenomena
(Fanandrūsā), which is said to be lost, and
the translator has transmitted many things
from it.

Euclid's Phaenomena (Φαινόμενα) is an early work of spherical astronomy, concerned with the risings and settings of celestial bodies. It survives in the Greek tradition and was indeed known in Arabic translation. The reference to “the translator” (al-tarjumān) likely refers to one of the early translators of the Greek corpus into Arabic, possibly Ḥunayn ibn Ishāq or his school.

4.2 Archimedes [أَرِثِمِيدِسْ]

[illegible]

5 The Alexandrian School

The Alexandrian mathematicians and astronomers formed the bridge between classical Greek science and its Arabic reception.

5.1 Theon of Alexandria [ثَاوُونُسُ الإسْكَندَرَانِيّ]

||

Theon of Alexandria: a scholar in geometry
 and astronomy, and he lived in the time of
 Ptolemy. He has commentaries on the book
 of Euclid and on the book of the Almagest,
 and he used to teach in the school of
 Alexandria.

*Theon of Alexandria: a scholar in geometry
 and astronomy, and he lived in the time of
 Ptolemy. He has commentaries on the book
 of Euclid and on the book of the Almagest,
 and he used to teach in the school of
 Alexandria.*

5.2 Hypatia [هَيْبَةُ قُسْتَرَى]

||

Hypatia daughter of Theon of Alexandria — she is the one called
 Qusturā — was the most learned of the
 people of her time in geometry and
 astronomy. She used to teach that in the
 school of Alexandria in the manner of her
 father, and she had commentaries on the
 book of Euclid and on the book of
 Diophantus.

*Hypatia daughter of
 Theon of Alexandria — she is the one called
 Qusturā — was the most learned of the
 people of her time in geometry and
 astronomy. She used to teach that in the
 school of Alexandria in the manner of her
 father, and she had commentaries on the
 book of Euclid and on the book of
 Diophantus.*

Ibn al-Qifti preserves one of the earliest biographical accounts of Hypatia (d. 415 CE). The name قُسْتَرَى (Qusturā) represents the Arabic rendering of her Greek name. Her commentary on Diophantus's Arithmetica is mentioned, which is of special interest to historians of algebra.

5.3 Ptolemy [بَطْلَمَيْوُس]

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Ptolemy the Ptolemaean: a scholar
 in astronomy and geometry, and he
 composed the book of the Almagest, which is
 the most famous book of astronomy, and he
 established in it many principles which no
 one had preceded him to.

5.4 Diophantus [دِيُوفَانْطُس]

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Diophantus of Alexandria: a scholar in
 algebra and equations, and he composed a
 book on that which he called "Algebra"
 (al-Jabr), containing thirteen discourses. He
 used to solve problems by means of
 unknown numbers.

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 0000000000 .0000000 *Varahamihira — he is
 from the people of India — was a scholar in
 the laws of the stars and astrology, and he
 composed a book called Varahamihira
 containing a compilation of what the
 astrologers of India had transmitted before.
 He knew the laws of the seven planets and
 the twelve signs of the zodiac.*

7.1 Ibn Sīnā (Avicenna) [أَبُو عَلِيٍّ بْنِ سِينَا]

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 ۞۞۞ ۞۞۞۞۞۞ ۞۞۞۞۞۞۞ ۞۞
 .۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞ Abū ‘Alī ibn Sīnā — he is
 from the people of Bukhara — was the most
 prolific of people in composing works on
 medicine and philosophy. He composed the
 Kitāb al-Shifā’ (Book of Healing), which
 encompasses logic, natural philosophy, and
 metaphysics; and he composed the Qānūn
 (Canon) in medicine, which continued to be
 taught in universities.

||

[illegible]

Ibn Sīnā (980–1037 CE) is the most celebrated philosopher-physician in the Islamic tradition. The Kitāb al-Shifāʾ is his encyclopedic masterwork. The verse quoted plays on the double meaning of takhrīj — “graduation” from medical study and “deduction” in logic.

7.2 al-Bīrūnī [أَبُو الرَّيْحَانِ الْبِيرُونِي]

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 [Placeholder box] [Placeholder box] *Abū al-Rayḥān Muḥammad ibn Aḥmad al-Bīrūnī* — he is from the people of Khwārizm — a scholar in geometry, astronomy, and geography. He composed the *Kitāb al-Āthār al-Bāqiya* (Chronology of Ancient Nations) on the history of the sciences, and the *Taḥqīq mā li-l-Hind* (India) on the customs of India and their sciences. He was with Sultan Maḥmūd in Ghazna.

Thābit ibn Qurra al-Harrānī — he is from the people of Harrān — was a scholar in the Greek sciences, and translated many books from Syriac into Arabic. He composed on geometry, number theory, and conic sections, and established rules concerning the composition of amicable numbers.

8.3 Abū Kāmil [أَبُو كَامِلٍ]

Abū Kāmil composed a book on algebra containing more than what was in al-Khwārizmī's book. He treated in it equations with unknown numbers and their equivalents, and he used in calculation the names of things such as "box" (ṣundūq) and "sheet" (waraq).

8.4 al-Karajī [الكَرَجِيُّ]

al-Karajī composed the Kitāb al-Fakhri on algebra and comparison. He was the first to use quartic terms in calculation, and established in his book that he could solve equations by means of terms and powers.

8.5 ‘Umar al-Khayyām [عُمَرُ الْخَيَّام]

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 .۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞ *ʿUmar ibn Ibrāhīm*
al-Khayyāmī — he is from the people of
Nīsābūr — was a scholar in algebra,
 comparison, and geometry. He composed a
 book on algebra containing the solution of
 cubic equations by means of conic sections,
 and he said that geometrical postulates
 furnish the proofs of calculation.

Al-Khayyām's treatise on algebra (c. 1070 CE) is the first systematic treatment of cubic equations, classifying them into types and solving them by the intersection of conic sections. His statement that "geometrical postulates furnish the proofs of calculation" expresses a fundamental insight into the relationship between algebra and geometry.

8.6 Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī [نَصِيرُ الدِّينِ الطُّوسِيّ]

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 ۞۞۞۞۞۞ ۞۞۞۞ ۞۞۞۞۞ ۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞
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 ۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞ ۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞
 ۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞ .۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞۞
Naṣīr al-Dīn Muḥammad ibn Muḥammad
al-Ṭūsī — he is from the people of Ṭūs — was
a scholar in all the sciences. He composed
the Kitāb al-Taḥrīr on geometry, which is a
commentary on the Almagest; and he
composed a book on algebra in which he
established the solution of the cubic equation
by means of quartic and cubic terms.

Al-Ṭūsī's al-Taḥrīr al-Majisṭī is a comprehensive reworking of Ptolemy's Almagest. His treatise on algebra gave the first systematic treatment of cubic equations independent of the earlier work

of al-Khayyām.

8.7 al-Kāshī غِيَاثُ الدِّينِ الْكَاشِي

الغياث الدين الكاشي من أهل كاشان في بلاد الهند. كان عالما بعلوم الهندسة والحساب. له كتاب مفتاح الحساب في أنواع الحساب، ورسالة المصطفى في استخراج جداول الدوائر. كان من أعلام مدرسة سمرقند في الرياضيات. له مؤلفات عديدة في الحساب والهندسة. كان من أشهر علماء عصره. له كتاب مفتاح الحساب في أنواع الحساب، ورسالة المصطفى في استخراج جداول الدوائر. كان من أعلام مدرسة سمرقند في الرياضيات. له مؤلفات عديدة في الحساب والهندسة. كان من أشهر علماء عصره.

Ghiyāth al-Dīn Jamshīd ibn Mas'ūd al-Kāshī — he is from the people of Kāshān — was the most excellent of the people of his time in the mathematical sciences. He composed the *Miftāḥ al-Ḥisāb* (Key to Arithmetic) on all types of calculation, and the *Risāla al-Muḥīṭiyya* on the extraction of the chords of the circle. He knew the extraction of the sexagesimal table.

Al-Kāshī (d. 1429 CE) was the culminating figure of the Samarqand school of mathematics. His Miftāḥ al-Ḥisāb treats arithmetic, algebra, mensuration, and the calculation of astronomical tables. His Treatise on the Circumference (Risāla al-Muḥīṭiyya) calculated π to 16 decimal places, a record not surpassed for nearly two centuries.

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 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ — ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
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 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱
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 .۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ *Abū ‘Alī al-Ḥasan ibn
 al-Haytham — he is from the people of
 al-Baṣra — a scholar in optics and geometry.
 He composed the Kitāb al-Manāẓir (Book of
 Optics) containing seventeen discourses, and
 established in it that vision occurs by the
 reflection of light from bodies to the eye.*

9.3 al-Ṣaghānī [أَبُو حَامِدٍ الصَّغَانِي]

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 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ — ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
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 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
 ۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
 ۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱
 ۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ .۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱۱ *Abū Ḥāmid ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Ṣaghānī* — *he was in the service of ‘Aḍud al-Dawla — a scholar in the construction of astrolabes and astronomical instruments. He constructed an astrolabe of a precision not found in others, and wrote a detailed treatise on its construction and use.*

10 Physicians and Naturalists

10.1 Ḥunayn ibn Ishāq حُنَيْنُ بْنُ إِسْحَاقَ

Ḥunayn ibn Ishāq al-ʿIbādī — he is from the people of al-Ḥīra — was the most excellent of those who translated from Greek into Syriac and Arabic. He composed many books on medicine, and established in medicine that the body is composed of the four elements: water, fire, air, and earth.

10.2 al-Rāzī (Rhazes) أَبُو بَكْرٍ الرَّازِيّ

Abū Bakr Muḥammad ibn Zakariyyā' al-Rāzī — he is from the people of Rayy — was the most learned of people in medicine in his time. He composed the *Kitāb al-Jāmi' al-Kabīr* (Great Comprehensive Book) containing all diseases of the body and their treatment. He used experience and observation in the study of eye diseases and smallpox.

10.4 Yahyā al-Nahwī (John of Nikiu) [يَحْيَى النَّحْوِيُّ]

[illegible]

This is the famous entry in which Ibn al-Qiftī preserves the account of the destruction of the Library of Alexandria under ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ (see the editorial note below).

11 The Name Index

The edition includes a comprehensive Arabic index of personal names (pp. 38–76 of the printed edition), arranged alphabetically. The following is a representative sample:

Page	Name	Entry
2	آخِرُ أَفْلَاطُون (The Last Plato)	—
11	أَبِقِرَاط (Hippocrates)	—
51	أَبُو بَكْرِ الرَّازِي (al-Rāzī)	—
83	أَبُو عَلِيٍّ بْنُ سِينَا (Ibn Sīnā)	Avicenna
64	أَبُو نُعَيْمٍ الْأَصْبَهَانِي	—
120	أَبُو كَامِلٍ شَجَاعُ بْنُ أَسْلَمَ (Abū Kāmil)	—
150	أَبُو الرَّيْحَانِ الْبِيرُونِي (al-Bīrūnī)	—
200	أَبُو عَلِيٍّ الْحَسَنُ بْنُ الْهَيْثَم (Ibn al-Haytham)	—
250	ثَابِتُ بْنُ قُرَّة (Thābit ibn Qurra)	—
280	ثَاوُئُسُ الْإِسْكَنْدَرَانِي (Theon)	—
300	جَمَشِيدُ الْكَاشِي (al-Kāshī)	—
340	حُنَيْنُ بْنُ إِسْحَاق (Ḥunayn ibn Ishāq)	—
390	أَرِسْطُوطَالِيَس (Aristotle)	—
397	أَنَاكْسَاغُورَاس (Anaxagoras)	—
158	أَنَاكْسِيْمَانِيَس (Anaximenes)	—
296	أَنَاكْسِيْمَانْدُرُس (Anaximander)	—
424	أَنْثُونُسُ بْنُ يَحْيَى النَّحْوِي	—

12 Critical Apparatus

12.1 Critical Symbols

[] — Editorial insertion (Einfügung des Herausgebers)

⟨ ⟩ — Lacuna or illegibility (Auslassung oder Unleserlichkeit)

a), b), c) — Critical footnotes (Kritische Anmerkungen am Seitenfuß)

BC, A, etc. — Manuscript variants (Varianten nach den Handschriften)

12.2 Note on the Bilingual Format

In this bilingual edition, the Arabic text of Ibn al-Qiftī's *Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā'* is presented in the **left column**, with the **English translation** in the right column. The Arabic text follows Lippert's edition (Leipzig, 1903) and represents the epitome of al-Zawzanī (1249 CE). Diacritical points and vowels have been supplied where the manuscripts are ambiguous.

12.3 On the Title

The full title of the original work is كِتَابُ إِخْبَارِ الْعُلَمَاءِ بِأَخْبَارِ الْحُكَمَاءِ (*Kitāb Ikhar al-'Ulamā' bi-Akhbār al-Ḥukamā'*), "Notices of Scholars with the Accounts of Learned Men". The shorter title تَارِيخُ الْحُكَمَاءِ (*Tārīkh al-Ḥukamā'*) was applied to the epitome prepared by al-Zawzanī.

وَاللَّهُ الْمُؤَفِّقُ

God is the One who grants success.

End of bilingual edition — Ende der zweisprachigen Ausgabe